

Mental Representation and Skill

Excerpt from Justin Slocum Bailey's article "Teaching Latin to Humans: How to Honor both the Language and the Learner"

Source: eidolon.pub

There are lots of ways of framing what it takes to know a language. Some are true to what we know about language and the brain; some aren't. My favorite linguistically and cognitively sound way is articulated by Bill VanPatten: Knowing a language has two faces*, (1) a "Mental Representation" (MR) of the language and (2) "Skill" in the language.

Your MR is the implicit knowledge your brain uses to interpret or produce language, covering syntax, vocabulary, semantics, morphology, and phonology. Your MR of English is what tells you that *Sappho takes the cake* is fine, but something's missing from **Sappho puts the cake*. It's what lets you know you can *reread* or *rethink*, but you can't **resleep* or **redrink*, and that you can *retell a story*, but not *retell me your name*. It's how you know what the *s* on the end of *results* does both in *Your results are in* and in *This results in confusion*. It's how you know the pairs *live/lived*, *give/gave*, and *drive/drove*, and how you know the zillion uses of *up* and the one use of *galore*. It's why you wonder whether *darcel* is a real English word, but not whether *kpyxj* is. In short, MR is the thing in your brain that tells you what's possible in a particular language and what isn't.

How did you get your MR of English? The answer is surprisingly simple: by understanding messages delivered to you in English. This is how any person gets an MR of any language. It doesn't matter whether the language is ancient or modern, dead or alive, highly inflected or not, or whether the learner is young or old, inclined to analysis or not, acquiring her first language or her twelfth. All that matters is whether it's a *human* language and the learner has a *human* brain.

When your brain matches the form of language you hear or read to its meaning, your MR grows. The brain, apparently, is wired to process linguistic input and integrate it into its picture of the language — its MR. It does not seem to be wired to turn information *about* a language, such as that presented in paradigms or teachers' explanations, into MR. No matter how well it is taught, knowledge about a language tends to remain just that: *knowledge about*, rather than *competence in*. Actual competence relies on MR developed through vast input. Since this input has to be understood in order to be processed, it is often called comprehensible input (CI).

If MR is what a language-knowing brain knows, linguistic Skill is what a language-knowing person can *do*, the application of MR to target tasks such as following an argument, explaining a thought, or savoring an epigram. Skill does *not* refer to the ability to decline a third-declension i-stem adjective, identify a concessive clause, or convert a sentence from direct to indirect speech. These are extra-linguistic tasks in the sense that they neither invoke nor enhance MR of a language, aren't part of communication, and aren't linked to the ability to engage in tasks such as holding a conversation or reading a book.

Actual linguistic Skill is the goal of any language course, ancient or modern. The only difference between learning a modern and a classical language is that, although developing MR of a classical language happens the exact same way as with any other language, the Skills most students pursue are different. They don't have to be — one can do the same things with Latin as with any other language — but the goal of reading texts is primary in most programs.

So, how does one develop linguistic Skill? First, by building the MR that is the foundation of Skill, and, second, by engaging in the target task itself. If you want to be good at reading Latin odes, you need a thorough MR of Latin and you need to read lots of Latin odes. If you want to be good at Latin small talk, you need a thorough MR of Latin and lots of Latin small talk.

Unfortunately, few programs provide the heaps of comprehensible input necessary for MR, with the result that when students try to read *they don't stand a chance of genuine comprehension*. Lacking a strong MR of Latin, students are literally trying to read a language they don't know.

Many teachers try to counter this by offering “reading strategies” such as paraphrasing and gapping or rules for reading, giving tips such as “when you see *ita ut*, anticipate a result clause,” or simply demanding that students constantly review grammar. But these are not ways of increasing one's ability to comprehend. They are ways of *coping with one's inability to comprehend*.

If I summon my explicit knowledge of grammar, vocabulary, or “reading strategies” to make sense of a sentence, I have not gotten better at understanding Latin; I have merely coped with my inability to understand Latin at that level. It's sometimes important or rewarding to be able to cope with texts above one's level. But why structure our Latin courses so that this is the best possible outcome?

The surest way to get genuine, real-time, Latin-as-Latin comprehension of advanced language is first to get genuine comprehension of slightly less advanced language, right down to the simplest *Salve*.

This is where teachers who adopt approach based on comprehensible input set themselves apart. They are learning how to furnish the input necessary for MR, which is necessary for linguistic Skill. It boils down to two things: (1) scads of reading material that is easy enough and interesting enough that students can and want to read dozens of pages at a sitting, and (2) speaking to students in the target language, which allows us to give loads of input at the exact level our students need, and to provide input of interest to our particular students, maximizing the likelihood that they will keep listening.

In a way, this is a cruel combination. Many Latin teachers aren't comfortable speaking Latin, because they either don't have a thorough MR of Latin or haven't had opportunities to interact in Latin. Worse, there are few published texts for which Novice and Intermediate Latin learners can measure their daily progress in number of books or chapters, rather than lines. This dearth of captivating, level-appropriate texts — not lack of aptitude, motivation, tools, or even skilled instruction — is the number one obstacle confronting anyone trying to learn Latin.

Fortunately, these are practical, not theoretical, problems. There's nothing about Latin or about the brain that creates these barriers. And hordes of Latin lovers are toppling these barriers for themselves and others.

* VanPatten, Bill. "The Two Faces of SLA: Mental Representation and Skill", in *International Journal of English Studies*, 10(1), 2010, pp. 1-18.

Extensive and Intensive Reading

By Justin Slocum Bailey

Source: indwellinglanguage.com

Extensive Reading and Intensive Reading are worthwhile for their own sakes and have valuable, but different, roles in a language course:

□ **Extensive Reading** is consuming large quantities of highly comprehensible texts. Besides being enjoyable if the texts are compelling, it is a powerful way of building one's Mental Representation of and overall comfort with the language.

Extensive Reading may be the only way a person not living in language immersion is likely to develop a broad vocabulary (including awareness of usage, register, collocations, and connotations), real-time processing of sentence structure, and a sense of what is normal in a language and what isn't.

□ **Intensive Reading** is interacting with a small amount of text for the sake of literary analysis or to complete a task (e.g., identifying the details of an argument). Like Extensive Reading, it can be highly enjoyable if the text is compelling. It can provide a type of literary pleasure and depth of insight that Extensive Reading does not. Ideally, it is done with a text whose "face value" meaning can be understood after a single pass; the Intensive Reading process then takes the reader's understanding or enjoyment of the text to a deeper level through attention to *how* the text accomplishes whatever it accomplishes.

Because Intensive Reading involves a low volume of text, it can be a good way of exercising readers' analytical skills, but plays only a very small role in improving the reader's knowledge of the language. It should therefore be used sparingly until learners have a fairly thorough Mental Representation of the target language.

NOTE: Many Latin programs involve either only Intensive Reading or *neither* type of reading. Deciphering or translating a text with the help of lexical and grammatical aids, for instance, is neither Extensive nor Intensive Reading. *If* one goes back through a text many times *after* deciphering it, so that one eventually has the experience of understanding it in real time without recourse to another language, those final rounds of reading-with-understanding do boost one's Mental Representation of the language. This is how most people alive today who can actually read

Latin as Latin got there, but few students do this, and it is generally less efficient and less enjoyable than Extensive Reading.

What is Extensive Reading?

Excerpt from “The Extensive Reading Foundation’s Guide to Extensive Reading”

Source: erfoundation.org

When students read extensively, they read very easy, enjoyable books to build their reading speed and reading fluency. The aim of Extensive Reading is to help the student become better at the skill of reading rather than reading to study the language itself. When students are reading extensively they READ:

Read quickly and

Enjoyably with

Adequate comprehension so they

Don’t need a dictionary

In order to read quickly and fluently (at least 150-200 words per minute or a little lower for beginning students), the reading must be easy. If there is too much unknown language on the page, it creates problems which slow the natural movement of the eye and affect comprehension and turn the fluent reading into a form of ‘study reading’.

Extensive Reading is sometimes known as Graded Reading or Sustained Silent Reading.

Why do Extensive Reading?

There are many reasons why Extensive Reading is good for language development. Extensive Reading:

1. allows students to meet the language in its natural context and see how it works in extended discourse beyond the language met in textbooks
2. builds vocabulary. When students read a lot, they meet thousands of words and lexical (word) patterns time and time again which helps them master them and predict what vocabulary and grammar may come next.
3. helps students to build reading speed and reading fluency which allows them to process the language more automatically leaving space in memory for other things

4. builds confidence, motivation, enjoyment and a love of reading which makes students more effective language users. It also helps lower any anxieties about language learning the students may have.
5. allows students to read or listen to a lot of English at or about their own ability level so they can develop good reading and listening habits
6. helps students get a sense of how grammatical patterns work in context. Textbooks and other study materials introduce language patterns but typically they don't appear often enough in a variety of contexts to facilitate a deep understanding of how the patterns work.

Don't Read, Reread

By Justin Slocum Bailey

Source: indwellinglanguage.com

It wouldn't be unfair of you to ask why I read a letter this morning written to someone other than me, or why I did so twice, once silently and once aloud, or why these were the fifth and sixth times this week that I had read this same letter.

"Curiously enough, one cannot *read* a book: one can only reread it." So claimed Vladimir Nabokov, on whose work I wrote my senior thesis some years ago. He continues, "A good reader, a major reader, an active and creative reader is a rereader," and goes on to defend this claim on the artistic grounds that, in order to enjoy and evaluate a book properly, one must be able to experience it as one experiences a painting, outside the linear passage of time, which one can do with a book only once one knows all its parts well enough to consider them as a simultaneous whole.*

Re-reading is of value not only for art-critical purposes or for the wonder of returning to a beloved book after a long interval. There is also the wise language learner's habit: rereading a text on the same day or on several consecutive days. There may be no better way for a language learner, once she has achieved a minimal level of proficiency, to obtain meaningful, understandable input in the target language, and there is almost certainly no better way to lock specific turns of phrase into one's mind.

If you struggle through a text, looking up a lot of words, perhaps translating here and there, you may, by the end, have understood the text, but you won't have done much for your fluency in the language.

One of the reasons such rereading is effective is that, while it may be rewarding to work one's way through a difficult text, the real language acquisition comes from then rereading the text so as to understand it in "real time." This may not happen until the severalth time through, but it's important to realize that it is not until one is able to read a text, with understanding and at a decent clip, that efficient language acquisition is taking place. If you struggle through a text, looking up a lot of words, perhaps translating here and there, you may, by the end, have understood the text, but you won't have done much for your fluency in the language.

I have found that rereading, along with its paramour, relistening, has been the single most potent factor in my acquisition of Latin. Currently, I am rereading the letters of Seneca to his protégé Lucilius—not only reading them again after having read them some time ago, but rereading the same letter several days in a row: For a week, I read the same letter over again every day; the next week, I read the next letter every day, and so on. Every Friday, I record myself reading the letter aloud, so that I can listen and relisten to the letters, usually while driving or doing chores.

My basic practice is to reread a text however many times it takes for me to be able to read it “full speed,” and then read it at least once more.

I am also reading and rereading the five-act comedies of the Roman playwright Terence, according to the following scheme: on Days 1 and 2, I read and reread Act I, on Days 3 and 4, I read and reread Act II, and so on. When I’ve finished the play this

way, I reread the entire thing, so that I’ve read through the play three times after two or three weeks. If the text were harder for me to understand, I would read each section even more times. My basic practice is to reread a text however many times it takes for me to be able to read it “full speed,” and then read it at least once more. (In some cases, as with Seneca’s letters, understanding comes quickly, but I still reread several times in order to thoroughly internalize not only the language itself, but also Seneca’s style and thought.)

When I told a friend about my rereading habit and mentioned a particular book whose 35 chapters I had read about fifteen times each, she said, “You must be pretty patient.” I’m not. My motivation for

My motivation for rereading is precisely that I don’t like to waste time.

rereading is precisely that I don’t like to waste time. From the perspective of second language acquisition, the only way to waste time reading is to read a text exactly once. If you never touch the text, you won’t waste any time. If you read the text many times, your fluency will skyrocket. Lots of language learners waste time by struggling through texts that are too difficult for them or by immediately moving on from a text without having absorbed much of its language or content. By rereading, you ensure that a text does all it can for your fluency, and that all the time you spend reading actually translates into increased fluency. (Note that, outside the realm of language acquisition, there might be lots of reasons to read a text exactly once, e.g., to gather news, to say you did, or to learn that you never want to read it again.)

So, find a text you think you might enjoy reading multiple times, and do it!

*Vladimir Nabokov, *Lectures On Literature*, New York: Harcourt, 1980